CYBER SAFETY GUY

iPHONE & iPAD PARENTAL CONTROLS

IOS SCREEN TIME — THE COMPLETE PARENT GUIDE

Screen Time is Apple's built-in parental controls system — no separate app needed. It gives parents genuine control over screen time, app access, explicit content, communications and purchases, all secured behind a passcode your child cannot bypass.

Here's how to set it up properly and what every setting actually does.

BUILT IN
No app download needed — already on every iPhone and iPad

52%
of UK teens have an iPhone
Statcounter (2024)

1
passcode locks all settings — your child cannot turn it off

0
default limits — Screen Time must be turned on manually

WHAT IOS SCREEN TIME CONTROLS

Downtime
Schedule hours when only approved apps work — great for bedtime and school. Your child cannot override it without the Screen Time passcode.

App Limits
Set daily time limits per app or per category (Social Networking, Games, Entertainment). The app greyes out when time is up.

Content & Privacy
Restrict explicit content, set app age ratings, control web browsing, block adult websites and limit what Siri can return.

Communication Limits
Control who your child can call, message and FaceTime — during screen time and during Downtime separately.

Location & Family Sharing
Share location between family members via Find My. Control which apps can access location data at device level.

Purchase Controls
Block in-app purchases entirely or require your Apple ID password for every download, including free apps.

WHY PARENTAL CONTROLS MATTER

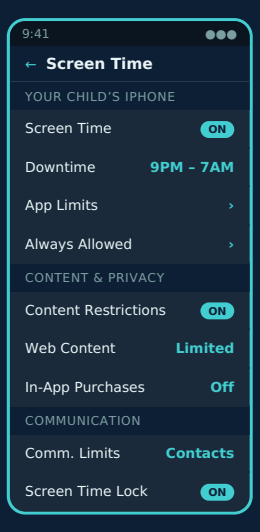
WITHOUT SCREEN TIME — RISKS

- ⚠ No time limits — a child can spend unlimited hours on any app, including social media at 2am.
- ⚠ Any app rated 17+ can be downloaded from the App Store without restriction.
- ⚠ Safari can access adult websites without any content filter applied.
- ⚠ In-app purchases can be completed using any saved payment method without a password.
- ⚠ Strangers can contact your child via iMessage, FaceTime and third-party apps without restriction.
- ⚠ No visibility into how long your child spends on each app or what they access.

WITH SCREEN TIME — WHAT YOU CAN DO

- ✓ Set Downtime hours so the device locks automatically at bedtime and during school.
- ✓ Restrict app downloads by age rating and require your Apple ID for every purchase.
- ✓ Limit web browsing to approved sites only, or block adult content automatically.
- ✓ Block in-app purchases entirely, or require a password for every transaction.
- ✓ Limit who can call or message your child — Contacts Only or specific people.
- ✓ Review weekly Screen Time reports showing exactly which apps were used and for how long.

SETTING IT UP — STEP BY STEP



STEP 1 — TURN ON
Enable Screen Time
Settings → Screen Time → Turn On Screen Time → tap **This is My Child's iPhone**. If setting up on your own phone first, select "This is My iPhone" then use Family Sharing.

STEP 2 — SECURE IT
Set a Screen Time Passcode
When prompted, set a Screen Time passcode. **Make it different from the device passcode.** This prevents your child from turning off Screen Time or changing any settings.

STEP 3 — SET DOWNTIME
Schedule offline hours
Screen Time → Downtime → toggle on → set start and end time. Only apps in Always Allowed will work during Downtime. Phone calls can still be permitted.

STEP 4 — RESTRICT
Content & Privacy Restrictions
Screen Time → Content & Privacy Restrictions → toggle on. This unlocks all the content controls below. Nothing is restricted until you turn this on.

TIP The Screen Time passcode is the single most important step. Without it, a child can go to Settings → Screen Time → Turn Off Screen Time and undo everything in seconds. Set a passcode you haven't used anywhere else.

KEY SETTINGS — WHAT PARENTS CAN CONTROL

DOWNTIME & APP LIMITS

- ▶ Screen Time → Downtime → set hours the device locks (school, bedtime)
- ▶ App Limits → Add Limit → select Social Networking or Games → set daily time
- ▶ Always Allowed → remove any apps you don't want accessible during Downtime
- ▶ Weekly Screen Time reports arrive automatically — review together, not in secret

ⓘ Downtime works best for under-13s. For teens, App Limits per category (2hrs Social Networking) is often a more proportionate approach.

CONTENT & PRIVACY RESTRICTIONS

- ▶ Content Restrictions → Web Content → Limit Adult Websites (auto-filter) or Allowed Websites Only (whitelist)
- ▶ Content Restrictions → Apps → set maximum age rating (e.g. 12+)
- ▶ Content Restrictions → Explicit Language → Don't Allow (limits Siri and dictation)
- ▶ Content Restrictions → Music, Podcasts & News → Explicit → Off

⚠ Web Content filters only apply to Safari. If your child uses Chrome or another browser, block it via App Limits or Always Allowed settings.

£ IN-APP PURCHASES

- ▶ Content & Privacy → iTunes & App Store Purchases → In-App Purchases → Don't Allow
- ▶ Installing Apps → Don't Allow (every new install requires your Apple ID)
- ▶ Require Password → Always (even free downloads need Apple ID approval)

COMMUNICATION LIMITS

- ▶ Screen Time → Communication Limits → During Screen Time → Contacts Only
- ▶ During Downtime → set to Specific Contacts or No One
- ▶ Settings → Messages → Filter Unknown Senders → On (unknown numbers go to a separate tab)

⚠ Communication Limits apply to Apple apps (Phone, Messages, FaceTime) only. For Instagram, Snapchat, WhatsApp and Discord — see CSG platform guides at guides.cybersafetyguy.com

COMMUNICATION SAFETY (IOS 17+)

- ▶ Settings → Screen Time → Communication Safety → verify it is active (on by default for under-18s in a Family Sharing group)
- ▶ Detects nudity in photos sent or received in Messages and blurs it automatically
- ▶ Child is prompted to contact a trusted adult — no images are sent to Apple or parents

ⓘ Communication Safety is on by default for under-18s in a Family Sharing group. If your child's account is set up outside Family Sharing, verify it is active manually. It works silently and without sharing images with Apple or parents.

LOCATION SHARING

- ▶ Set up Family Sharing: Settings → your name → Family Sharing → Add Member
- ▶ Child's device → Find My → Share My Location → select parent's Apple ID
- ▶ Settings → Privacy & Security → Location Services → set social apps to Never

ⓘ Talk to your child before enabling location sharing. Children who know they're located are more likely to speak up if something feels wrong, not less.

CONVERSATION STARTERS & RED FLAGS

CONVERSATION STARTERS

- Can you show me your three favourite apps and what you do on them?
- Has anyone ever messaged you who you didn't know? What did you do?
- Do you ever feel like you've spent too long on your phone? What does that feel like?
- If you saw something upsetting online, would you know what to do?
- I'm going to set up some Screen Time settings — can we look at them together?

TIP Setting up Screen Time with your child, not secretly, makes a real difference. Explain what each setting does and why. Children who understand the reason are far more likely to work with it rather than around it.

RED FLAGS TO WATCH FOR

- ⚑ Turning the phone face-down or closing apps quickly when you walk past.
- ⚑ Taking the phone to the bathroom or staying up late to use it in secret.
- ⚑ Becoming upset, anxious or tearful after being on their phone.
- ⚑ New contacts or "online friends" they won't tell you about.
- ⚑ Unexplained App Store charges or new apps you didn't approve.
- ⚑ Asking for unusual amounts of privacy or getting angry if you glance at the screen.

TIP Screen Time settings are a starting point. A child who knows they are trusted is more likely to come to you when something goes wrong online.

QUICK CHECK — 6 THINGS TO DO RIGHT NOW

- ☐ Turn on Screen Time and set a passcode different from the device passcode
- ☐ Set Downtime hours for bedtime and school — only Always Allowed apps work during Downtime
- ☐ Turn on Content & Privacy Restrictions and set Web Content to Limit Adult Websites
- ☐ Set Communication Limits to Contacts Only and turn on Filter Unknown Senders
- ☐ Verify Communication Safety is active — on by default for under-18s in Family Sharing, check manually if not
- ☐ Block in-app purchases and set App Store downloads to require your Apple ID

QUICK DO'S & DON'TS

DO

- ✓ Set Screen Time up together — explain each setting as you go.
- ✓ Keep the Screen Time passcode somewhere safe that only you know.
- ✓ Review the weekly Screen Time report with your child, not alone.
- ✓ Praise them when they come to you with something they've seen or received.

DON'T

- ✗ Turn Screen Time on secretly — your child will find it and it damages trust.
- ✗ Use the device passcode as the Screen Time passcode — they will guess it.
- ✗ Rely on Screen Time alone — conversation is still the most important safeguard.

WHERE TO GET HELP

Childline
0800 1111 • childline.org.uk
Free, confidential support for young people 24/7

CEOP (Child Exploitation)
ceop.police.uk
Report online grooming or sexual exploitation

Internet Matters
internetmatters.org
Guides and tools for parents on online safety

More CSG Guides
guides.cybersafetyguy.com
Platform guides, risk guides and parental controls

REMEMBER

Your involvement today helps your child make safer choices tomorrow.

Screen Time is a tool, not a solution. The most important thing you can do is keep the conversation open and make it easy for your child to come to you.

If your child shows you something worrying, your reaction in that moment decides whether they come to you again.

NEED TO TALK? CHILDLINE
childline.org.uk
0800 1111

YOU ARE NOT ALONE
We're here for you.